

**HARDWARE ABSTRACTION LAYER FOR MULTI-
PROVIDER
QUANTUM-CLASSICAL EXECUTION IN THE NEXAR
PLATFORM**

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ABSTRACT

The proliferation of quantum computing providers has created a critical need for unified execution infrastructure that abstracts the heterogeneous APIs, authentication mechanisms, and circuit formats of IBM Quantum, Amazon Braket, and Azure Quantum. This dissertation presents the Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL), a provider-agnostic execution service developed as part of the Nexar intelligent quantum-classical workload routing platform. The HAL exposes a unified FastAPI interface that enables transparent job submission, device discovery, status tracking, and result retrieval across multiple quantum and classical backends through a factory-based provider architecture. A key contribution is the implementation of a multi-tier job lifecycle management system incorporating priority-based queuing, device availability checking, Redis-backed persistence, and Google Cloud Pub/Sub messaging for real-time status notifications. The system further introduces a sandboxed Python code execution environment that allows users to submit raw Qiskit circuit code directly, executing it in a restricted namespace with configurable module allowlists and SIGALRM-based timeout protection. Calibration data extraction from IBM Quantum backends, including median CX error rates, T1/T2 coherence times, and readout error rates, is implemented with an in-memory cache (1-hour TTL) to minimise API overhead while providing up-to-date hardware quality metrics. The HAL also supports ten classical providers (AWS, Azure, IBM Cloud Functions, CPU, GPU, TPU, and local) under the same abstract interface, enabling the Nexar decision engine to route workloads to optimal execution targets without provider-specific logic. Evaluation demonstrates that the system successfully submits and tracks quantum jobs on IBM Quantum simulators and real devices, with the provider factory pattern enabling new backends to be integrated with zero modifications to routing or analysis components.

Keywords: hardware abstraction layer, quantum computing, multi-provider execution, job lifecycle management, Qiskit, FastAPI, sandboxed execution

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Description
API	Application Programming Interface
AWS	Amazon Web Services
CI/CD	Continuous Integration / Continuous Deployment
CX	Controlled-NOT (two-qubit entangling gate)
ECR	Echoed Cross Resonance gate
FastAPI	Fast Application Programming Interface (Python web framework)
GCP	Google Cloud Platform
GPU	Graphics Processing Unit
HAL	Hardware Abstraction Layer
HTTP	Hypertext Transfer Protocol
IBM	International Business Machines
JWT	JSON Web Token
NISQ	Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum
QASM	Quantum Assembly Language
QPU	Quantum Processing Unit
REST	Representational State Transfer
SDK	Software Development Kit
SIGALRM	Signal Alarm (POSIX signal for timer)
SX	Square Root of X gate (single-qubit gate)
T1	Qubit relaxation time
T2	Qubit dephasing time
TPU	Tensor Processing Unit
TTL	Time-To-Live
UUID	Universally Unique Identifier

Abbreviation	Description
VQE	Variational Quantum Eigensolver

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background and Literature Survey

The rapid expansion of quantum computing infrastructure across cloud providers has introduced a new class of engineering challenge: heterogeneous quantum execution environments. IBM Quantum, Amazon Braket, and Azure Quantum each expose distinct authentication mechanisms, circuit representation formats, job submission APIs, and result structures. IBM Quantum uses the Qiskit SDK with QiskitRuntimeService and Sampler primitives [1]; Amazon Braket uses its own Circuit abstraction and AwsDevice interface [2]; Microsoft Azure Quantum supports IonQ and Quantinuum backends through Azure-specific resource management APIs [3].

The problem of provider heterogeneity is not unique to quantum computing. In classical cloud computing, infrastructure abstraction layers such as libcloud, Terraform provider plugins, and OpenStack Nova compute drivers have demonstrated that a unified provider-agnostic interface significantly reduces engineering overhead and enables workload portability [4]. The hardware abstraction layer concept originates from operating systems design, where it describes the software layer that separates hardware-specific implementation from higher-level operating system services [5].

In the operating systems context, the HAL provides a uniform interface to hardware devices, allowing the kernel to interact with diverse hardware (CPUs of different architectures, varied I/O controllers, and storage devices) through a consistent contract. The same architectural pattern is applied here: the Nexar HAL provides a uniform interface to quantum and classical compute providers, allowing the Decision Engine and routing logic to dispatch workloads without provider-specific knowledge.

For quantum computing specifically, several frameworks have explored partial abstraction. Qiskit Runtime [1] provides session-based execution over IBM backends but is IBM-specific. Amazon Braket SDK [2] offers a Python interface for Braket-

supported devices (IonQ, Rigetti, OQC) but does not integrate with IBM or Azure. The XACC framework [6] provides a hardware-agnostic quantum programming interface but targets low-level gate-level programming rather than production job management. None of these frameworks address the full lifecycle of multi-provider quantum job management including scheduling, persistence, real-time status notification, device availability checking, and sandboxed user code execution.

The NISQ era [9] has shifted attention from theoretical algorithms to practical execution infrastructure. Researchers and developers increasingly need to compare results across multiple hardware vendors, validate algorithms on simulators before paying for real QPU time, and manage long-running variational workloads across queue waits that may exceed minutes or hours. This operational reality demands middleware that handles persistence, scheduling, and observability, concerns that pure SDK approaches do not address.

The research gap identified in this work is therefore the absence of a production-ready, provider-agnostic execution layer that supports the complete quantum job lifecycle across heterogeneous providers while also accommodating classical execution backends under a unified interface. The Nexar HAL directly addresses this gap by combining the abstraction quality of XACC with the operational maturity expected of cloud microservices.

1.2 Research Gap

Existing quantum cloud interfaces operate at the provider level, requiring application developers to integrate with each provider's SDK independently. When a routing platform such as Nexar needs to transparently dispatch workloads to the optimal backend, provider-specific coupling in the execution layer undermines modularity and makes it impossible to add new backends without modifying core routing logic.

Furthermore, existing frameworks do not address enterprise-grade operational concerns such as job persistence across service restarts (requiring Redis or similar backing stores), asynchronous status notification (requiring message broker integration), device availability-gated job queuing, or sandboxed execution of user-submitted circuit code with security restrictions.

Finally, current quantum SDKs expose hardware calibration data (qubit error rates, T1/T2 coherence times, gate durations) only when the developer explicitly queries them at low level. There is no equivalent of the calibration-aware device listing that would let a routing engine select backends based on noise quality. The HAL closes this gap by surfacing aggregated calibration metrics through its device listing API with caching to keep the operation efficient.

1.3 Research Problem

How can a unified hardware abstraction layer be designed that supports transparent job submission, status tracking, result retrieval, and device management across heterogeneous quantum and classical compute providers, while providing production-grade features including job persistence, real-time messaging, scheduled execution, calibration-aware device listing, and secure user code execution?

This research problem decomposes into several technical sub-questions:

1. How can the abstract interface be structured to support both quantum (circuit-based) and classical (task-based) execution while sharing common lifecycle management?
2. How can job state be reliably persisted across container restarts in serverless deployments such as Cloud Run, where containers are ephemeral?
3. How can user-submitted Qiskit code be safely executed without exposing the host environment to file-system, network, or process abuse?
4. How can calibration data be served at acceptable latency despite the per-qubit query cost on 100+ qubit devices?
5. How can scheduled and queue-on-unavailability execution flows be implemented without sacrificing the immediate-response semantics of high-priority jobs?

1.4 Research Objectives

6. To design and implement a factory-based provider architecture that enables multi-provider quantum and classical job execution through a single unified interface.

7. To implement a complete job lifecycle management system supporting priority queuing, device availability checking, scheduled execution, and Redis-backed persistence.
8. To develop a sandboxed Python code execution environment that enables direct Qiskit circuit code submission with security restrictions and timeout protection.
9. To implement IBM Quantum calibration data extraction with caching, providing hardware quality metrics (error rates, coherence times) through the HAL API.
10. To integrate Google Cloud Pub/Sub messaging for real-time job status notification across distributed system components.
11. To evaluate the HAL's correctness, extensibility, and operational capabilities through functional testing and integration with the Nexar decision engine.

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Methodology

The Hardware Abstraction Layer was developed following an iterative, interface-driven design methodology. The core principle was to define abstract interfaces first (BaseProvider, QuantumProvider, ClassicalProvider) and implement concrete providers against those contracts. This approach, analogous to the abstract factory pattern from software design patterns literature [7], ensures that the routing and analysis components of Nexar interact exclusively with abstract types, maintaining strict separation of concerns.

The implementation stack consists of FastAPI (Python) for the REST interface, Pydantic for request/response validation, Qiskit Runtime SDK for IBM Quantum integration, and Redis for job state persistence. Configuration is managed through pydantic-settings, which loads parameters from environment variables and .env files.

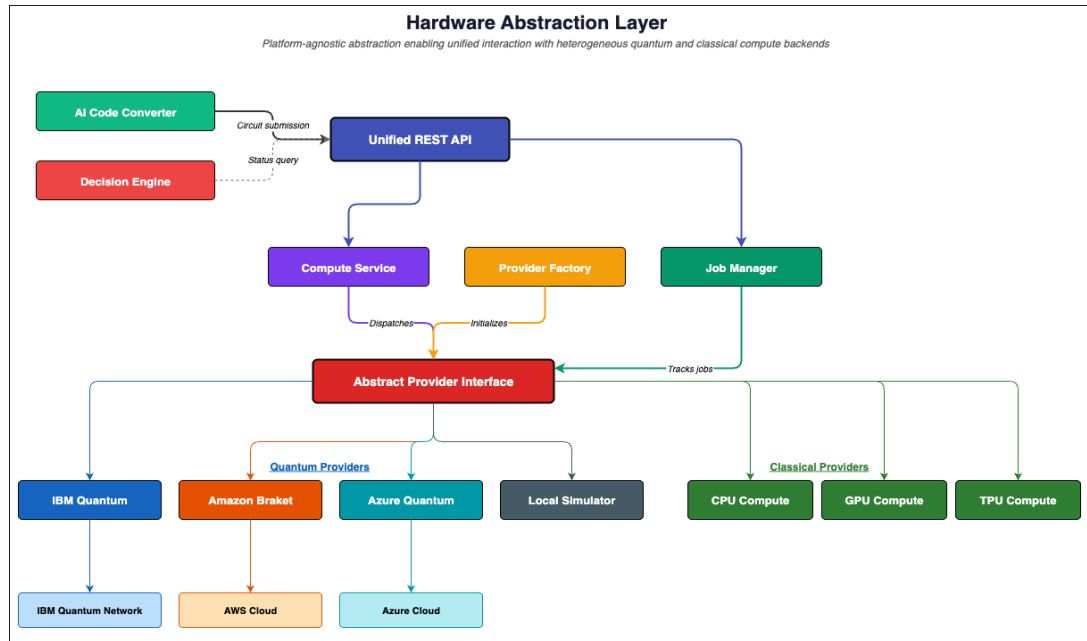
Development followed an iterative cycle: (1) define an abstract interface; (2) implement a stub concrete provider returning mock data; (3) implement a real provider for IBM Quantum; (4) wire the provider into the JobManager and API; (5) write unit and integration tests; (6) refine the interface as needs emerged. This cycle was repeated for each lifecycle feature (priority queuing, scheduling, availability checking, code sandboxing).

2.2 System Architecture

The HAL is deployed as one of six microservices in the Nexar platform, running on port 8004 as a FastAPI application containerised with Docker and deployed to Google Cloud Run. It receives job submission requests from the Nexar API Gateway (port 3000) after the Decision Engine (port 8003) has determined the optimal execution target.

Figure 2.1 illustrates the high-level architecture of the HAL service, showing how upstream Nexar components (AI Code Converter and Decision Engine) interact with the Unified REST API, which dispatches work through the Compute Service, Provider

Factory, and Job Manager. These internal components delegate execution to the Abstract Provider Interface, which fans out to concrete quantum providers (IBM Quantum, Amazon Braket, Azure Quantum, Local Simulator) and classical providers (CPU, GPU, TPU compute).



The internal architecture consists of four layers:

- API Layer: FastAPI router exposing REST endpoints for job submission, status, results, device listing, and scheduling.
- Service Layer: ComputeService orchestrates provider interactions; JobManager manages the job lifecycle.
- Provider Layer: Ten concrete provider implementations behind the BaseProvider, QuantumProvider, and ClassicalProvider abstract interfaces.
- Infrastructure Layer: Redis client (with in-memory fallback), Google Cloud Pub/Sub client, and configuration management via pydantic-settings.

2.3 Provider Architecture

The provider hierarchy follows a three-level abstract class structure:

2.3.1 BaseProvider (abstract)

Defines the core interface with `list_devices()`, `get_job_status()`, `get_job_result()`, and `execute_batch()` methods. All providers, both quantum and classical, implement this base.

2.3.2 QuantumProvider (abstract, extends BaseProvider)

Adds `execute_circuit(circuit, device_name, shots) → job_id`, with a default batch implementation that loops `execute_circuit` calls. Concrete providers may override `execute_batch` with provider-specific batch optimisation (as IBM does).

2.3.3 ClassicalProvider (abstract, extends BaseProvider)

Adds `execute_task(task, device_name) → job_id`, with a default batch implementation looping `execute_task` calls.

Concrete implementations are registered at service startup via the factory pattern. Figure 2.2 shows the resulting class hierarchy and Table 2.1 lists all registered providers.

Figure 2.2 – HAL Provider Class Hierarchy

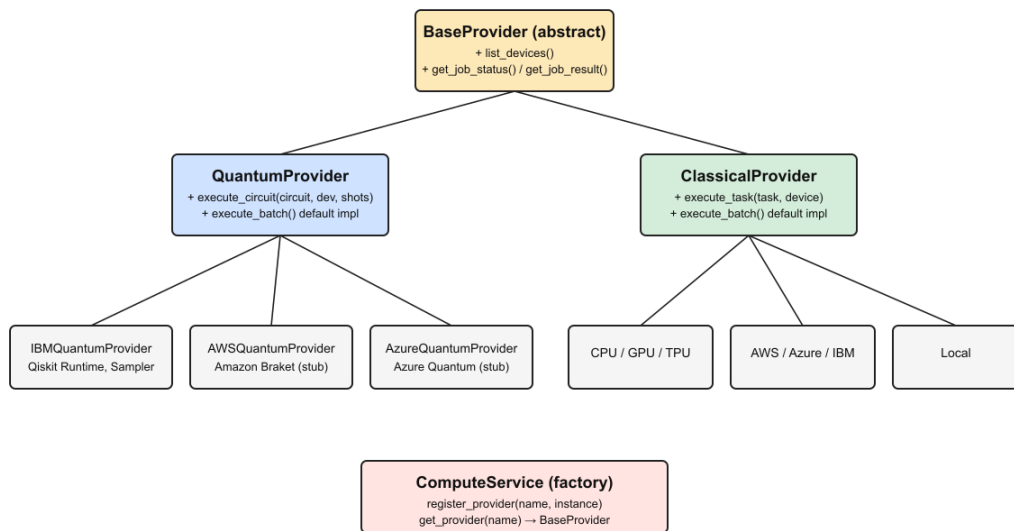


Table 2.1: Registered providers and their capabilities

Provider Name	Type	Backend
ibm-quantum	Quantum	IBM Quantum (Eagle, Heron)
aws-quantum	Quantum	Amazon Braket (IonQ, Rigetti)
azure-quantum	Quantum	Azure Quantum (IonQ, Quantinuum)
aws-classical	Classical	AWS Lambda / EC2
azure-classical	Classical	Azure Functions
ibm-classical	Classical	IBM Cloud Functions
local-classical	Classical	Local process execution
cpu-classical	Classical	Dedicated CPU compute node
gpu-classical	Classical	GPU compute (CUDA)
tpu-classical	Classical	TPU compute (Google)

The `ComputeService` maintains a dictionary mapping provider names to provider instances. New providers can be added by implementing the appropriate abstract class and registering with `compute_service.register_provider()`, requiring zero changes to routing or API logic.

2.4 IBM Quantum Provider Implementation

The `IBMQuantumProvider` is the most fully implemented quantum provider, integrating with the Qiskit Runtime platform through `QiskitRuntimeService`. It supports two credential modes: token-based (`IBM_QUANTUM_TOKEN` environment variable) and default credentials (saved account or environment variables).

Circuit execution uses Qiskit's `Sampler` primitive. Before submission, circuits are transpiled using `generate_preset_pass_manager` with `optimization_level=1` targeting the selected backend's gate set and coupling map. This transpilation step is critical: it maps the logical circuit to the physical qubit topology and decomposes gates to the basis gate set (ECR/CX, SX, RZ for Eagle processors). Two execution modes are configurable via `IBM_EXECUTION_MODE`: 'session' (creates a Qiskit Session context for reduced queue times, requires a paid plan) and 'direct' (submits directly to backend, compatible with all plans).

Batch execution is optimised: all circuits in a batch are transpiled and submitted in a single `Sampler.run()` call, receiving a single job ID. Individual circuit results are indexed by appending a colon-separated index (e.g., 'job123abc:0', 'job123abc:1'), allowing per-circuit result retrieval from the unified job.

Job status is mapped from IBM's status strings ('Initializing', 'Queued', 'Validating', 'Running', 'Done', 'Error', 'Cancelled') to standardised HAL status codes ('PENDING', 'QUEUED', 'RUNNING', 'COMPLETED', 'FAILED', 'CANCELLED') via a lookup dictionary.

Result extraction handles the `PubResult` format returned by `Sampler`, traversing data registers ('meas', 'c') to locate `BitArray` objects with `get_counts()` methods. A fallback traversal of all register attributes handles non-standard register names, ensuring compatibility with arbitrary user-defined classical registers.

2.5 Calibration Data Extraction

A distinctive feature of the HAL is its ability to extract hardware calibration metrics from IBM Quantum backends and expose them through the device listing API. This information enables the Decision Engine and frontend to display hardware quality context alongside routing recommendations.

Calibration extraction reads from `backend.target` (the `BackendV2` target object containing per-gate, per-qubit noise properties):

- Two-qubit gate errors: Iterates ECR, CX, CZ gate entries in target, collecting error and duration values.
- Single-qubit gate errors: Iterates SX, X, RZ gate entries, using the first gate type with available data.
- Readout errors: Collected from the 'measure' operation entries in target.
- T1/T2 coherence times: Retrieved via `backend.qubit_properties(i)` for each qubit, converting seconds to microseconds.

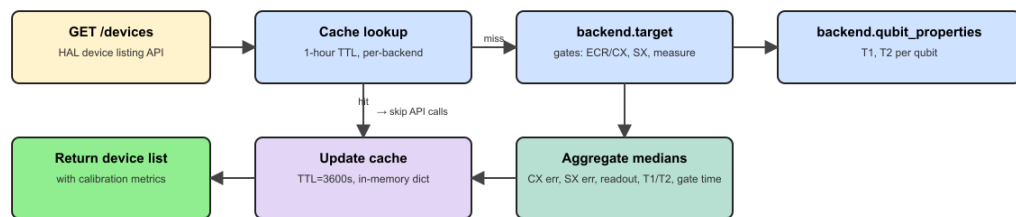
Median values are computed using Python's `statistics.median()`, providing a single representative value per metric that is robust to outlier qubits. Results are cached per

backend name with a 1-hour TTL (matching IBM's approximately daily recalibration cycle), preventing excessive API calls during repeated device listing requests.

Table 2.5: IBM Quantum calibration metrics extracted by HAL

Metric	Description	Source
median_cx_error	Median 2-qubit gate error	target[ECR/CX/CZ]
median_sx_error	Median single-qubit gate error	target[SX/X/RZ]
median_readout_error	Median measurement error	target[measure]
median_t1_us	Median T1 relaxation time (μ s)	qubit_properties.t1
median_t2_us	Median T2 dephasing time (μ s)	qubit_properties.t2
median_gate_time_ns	Median gate duration (ns)	target[*].duration

Figure 2.5 – IBM Quantum Calibration Extraction Pipeline



2.6 Job Lifecycle Management

The JobManager class implements the complete job lifecycle using a combination of in-memory structures, Redis persistence, and background threads.

Two background daemon threads run continuously:

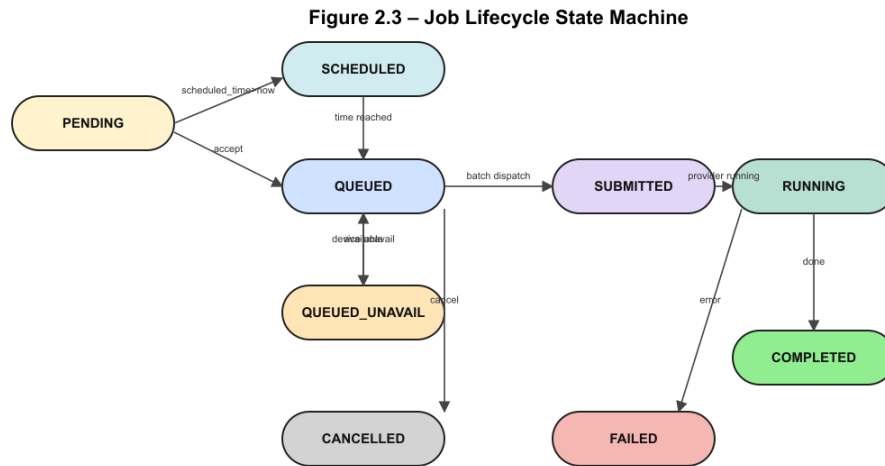
- Monitor thread (2-second interval): Processes pending job queues, triggering batch execution when either MAX_BATCH_SIZE (10) is reached or the oldest job's wait time exceeds the strategy threshold (1 second for TIME strategy, 10 seconds for COST strategy).

- Scheduler thread (1-second interval): Polls scheduled jobs, moving any whose `scheduled_time` has passed to the active queue for immediate execution.

Priority handling: HIGH-priority jobs bypass the pending queue and execute immediately. STANDARD-priority jobs enter the provider+device-keyed pending queue and wait for batch assembly. The provider+device key (e.g., 'ibm-quantum|ibm_brisbane') ensures that batches are only assembled from jobs targeting the same backend, since most provider SDKs only support batch submission to a single device.

Table 2.2: Job state transitions and triggers

From State	To State	Trigger
PENDING	QUEUED	Job accepted by JobManager
PENDING	SCHEDULED	<code>scheduled_time</code> is in the future
SCHEDULED	QUEUED	Scheduler thread detects <code>scheduled_time</code> reached
QUEUED	QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE	Device unavailable + <code>queue_if_unavailable=True</code>
QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE	QUEUED	Monitor thread detects device available
QUEUED	SUBMITTED	Batch dispatched to provider
SUBMITTED	RUNNING	Provider reports running status
RUNNING	COMPLETED	Provider reports done
Any	FAILED	Execution or provider error
Any	CANCELLED	User cancels via API



2.7 Redis-Backed Persistence

Job state is persisted to Redis using three key namespaces, summarised in Table 2.4. A RedisClient wrapper provides transparent fallback to in-memory dictionaries when Redis is unavailable or not configured (REDIS_URL not set). This design ensures the HAL operates correctly in development environments without a Redis deployment while supporting production persistence when configured.

Jobs are loaded from Redis on service startup (`load_jobs_from_redis()`), enabling recovery of in-flight jobs after container restarts, which is a critical operational requirement for Cloud Run deployments where containers may be replaced during updates.

Table 2.4: Redis key schema for job persistence

Redis Key	Type	Purpose
hal:jobs	Hash	All jobs by job_id (JSON-serialised JobSubmission)
hal:scheduled_jobs	Hash	Scheduled job metadata

Redis Key	Type	Purpose
hal:scheduled_jobs:by_time	Sorted Set	Time-indexed scheduled jobs (score = Unix ts)

2.8 Google Cloud Pub/Sub Messaging

Every job state transition triggers a Pub/Sub message published to the 'hal-job-updates' topic. Message payloads include: `job_id`, `provider_job_id`, `status`, `provider`, `device`, `timestamp`, and context-specific fields (`scheduled_for` for SCHEDULED, `reason` for QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE, `result` for COMPLETED, `error` for FAILED).

The `MessagingClient` is an abstract base class with a `publish_message()` abstract method. `GooglePubSubMessagingClient` implements this interface for GCP. The factory returns `None` if Google Cloud credentials are not configured, with `JobManager` performing a null check before publishing. This design allows the HAL to operate without Pub/Sub in environments where it is not needed.

2.9 Sandboxed Python Code Execution

The `execute_python_code` endpoint enables users to submit raw Python code defining a Qiskit circuit, which the HAL executes in a sandboxed environment before submitting to the quantum backend. Security is implemented through four mechanisms:

2.9.1 Restricted builtins

A custom `__builtins__` dictionary is constructed containing only safe built-in functions (`abs`, `all`, `any`, `bool`, `dict`, `enumerate`, `filter`, `float`, `int`, `isinstance`, `iter`, `len`, `list`, `map`, `max`, `min`, `range`, `round`, `set`, `sorted`, `str`, `sum`, `tuple`, `type`, `zip`, `True`, `False`, `None`, `print`). Dangerous functions (`eval`, `exec`, `compile`, `open`, `unrestricted __import__`) are excluded.

2.9.2 Restricted imports

A custom `__import__` function is injected that checks the top-level module name against the configured allowlist (`SANDBOX_ALLOWED_MODULES`, default: `'qiskit,numpy,math'`) and raises `ImportError` for any module not in the list. This

prevents user code from importing `socket`, `subprocess`, `os`, or other modules that could be used to escape the sandbox.

2.9.3 Pre-loaded namespace

Qiskit components, NumPy, and math functions are pre-loaded into the execution namespace, eliminating the need for import statements in simple circuit code (Table 2.3).

Table 2.3: Sandbox allowed modules and pre-loaded namespace

Component	Purpose
QuantumCircuit	Qiskit class for circuit definition
QuantumRegister	Qubit register definition
ClassicalRegister	Classical register for measurements
Parameter	Symbolic gate parameters
np / numpy	Numerical computation
math	Standard math functions
pi, sqrt, sin, cos, exp	Pre-loaded math shortcuts

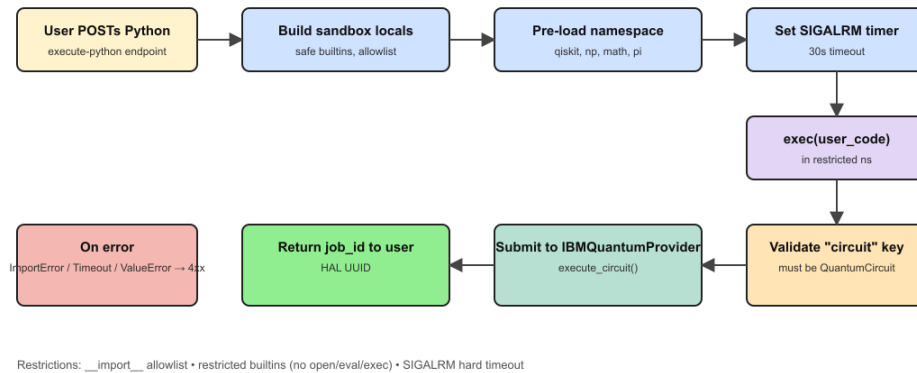
2.9.4 Timeout protection

On POSIX systems, `SIGALRM` is used to interrupt code execution exceeding `PYTHON_EXEC_TIMEOUT` seconds (default: 30). A custom `SandboxTimeoutError` exception is raised on timeout. Windows compatibility is preserved by checking for `SIGALRM` availability.

2.9.5 Circuit validation

After execution, `sandbox_locals` is checked for a 'circuit' key. The value must be an instance of Qiskit's `QuantumCircuit` class; otherwise a `ValueError` is raised with a descriptive message guiding the user to define the circuit variable correctly. Figure 2.4 summarises the end-to-end flow.

Figure 2.4 – Sandboxed Python Code Execution Flow



2.10 Device Availability Checking

`IBMQuantumProvider.check_device_availability()` queries `backend.status()` for the target device, reading `is_operational` and `pending_jobs` attributes. `DeviceAvailability.is_available` is a computed Pydantic field that returns `True` only when both `is_operational` is `True` and `pending_jobs` is below the `DEVICE_QUEUE_THRESHOLD` (default: 50).

When `queue_if_unavailable=True` is set on a job submission and the device is not available, the job is placed in a provider+device-keyed pending queue with status `QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE`. The monitor thread polls device availability every 2 seconds; when the device becomes available, jobs in that queue are promoted to `QUEUED` status.

2.11 API Design

The HAL exposes a RESTful API organised into logical groups:

- Provider discovery: `GET /api/providers`, `GET /api/v1/hardware/status`, `GET /api/v1/hardware/devices`
- Quantum execution: `POST /api/quantum/{provider_name}/execute` (QASM), `POST /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/execute-python` (Python code)

- Device management: GET /api/quantum/{provider_name}/devices, GET /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/devices/{device_name}/availability
- Job management: GET /api/quantum/jobs/{provider}/{id}, GET /api/quantum/jobs/{provider}/{id}/result
- Scheduling: POST /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/schedule, GET /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/scheduled-jobs, DELETE /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/scheduled-jobs/{job_id}
- Classical execution: POST /api/classical/{provider_name}/execute

2.12 Commercialisation Aspects

The HAL architecture has clear commercialisation potential as a standalone quantum job management middleware. Cloud providers offering quantum-as-a-service could deploy the HAL as a multi-tenant execution broker, abstracting their backends and adding value through features such as job scheduling, priority queuing, cost optimisation, and calibration-aware backend selection. The factory pattern makes it straightforward to add proprietary backends (photonic systems, neutral atom devices) without exposing provider-specific SDKs to end users.

Additionally, the sandboxed code execution feature addresses a significant barrier in quantum cloud adoption: users who want to submit circuit code without managing SDK installations can use the HAL's execute-python endpoint as a managed, secure execution environment. This is directly analogous to cloud notebook environments (AWS SageMaker, Google Colab) but specialised for quantum circuits.

Potential commercial deployment models include: (1) SaaS multi-tenant execution broker for academic institutions; (2) on-premises private deployment for enterprises with proprietary quantum hardware; (3) embedded library version of the provider abstraction for SDK-level integration into third-party platforms; (4) value-added services around the core execution layer (cost optimisation, error mitigation, job analytics).

2.13 Testing and Implementation

Testing was performed at three levels:

2.13.1 Unit tests

tests/test_ibm_quantum_provider.py and test_ibm_quantum_python_code.py verify circuit execution, Python code sandboxing, status mapping, batch result indexing, and calibration extraction. IBM credentials are mocked using unittest.mock to avoid real API calls in CI.

2.13.2 Integration tests

tests/test_job_manager.py verifies job submission, state transitions, scheduled job processing, and QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE handling using a real JobManager instance with in-memory Redis fallback.

2.13.3 Functional tests

tests/test_classical_provider.py and test_ibm_classical_provider.py verify classical provider registration, device listing, and task submission workflows.

Deployment was containerised via Docker, with a build that installs requirements and copies the application. The service is deployed to Google Cloud Run via GitHub Actions CI/CD, with the Qiskit IBM Runtime SDK and provider SDKs installed from requirements.txt. Environment variables (IBM_QUANTUM_TOKEN, AWS credentials, Redis URL, GCP project ID) are injected via Cloud Run service configuration.

3. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

3.1 Results

3.1.1 Provider registration and discovery

Provider registration and device discovery were verified by sending GET `/api/providers`, which returned all 10 registered providers. GET `/api/v1/hardware/devices` returned device listings from all providers, with IBM Quantum returning 7 backends including `ibm_brisbane` (127 qubits, Eagle processor), `ibm_sherbrooke` (127 qubits), and `ibm_aer_simulator` (statevector simulator).

Table 3.1: HAL API endpoint summary

Endpoint	Method	Description
<code>/api/health</code>	GET	Health check
<code>/api/providers</code>	GET	List registered providers
<code>/api/v1/hardware/status</code>	GET	HAL status with provider count
<code>/api/v1/hardware/devices</code>	GET	List all devices across providers
<code>/api/quantum/{provider}/devices</code>	GET	List provider devices
<code>/api/quantum/{provider}/execute</code>	POST	Execute QASM circuit
<code>/api/quantum/ibm-quantum/execute-python</code>	POST	Execute Python code
<code>/api/quantum/ibm-quantum/schedule</code>	POST	Schedule future job
<code>/api/quantum/ibm-quantum/scheduled-jobs</code>	GET	List scheduled jobs
<code>/api/quantum/ibm-quantum/scheduled-jobs/{id}</code>	DELETE	Cancel scheduled job
<code>/api/quantum/ibm-quantum/devices/{d}/availability</code>	GET	Device availability
<code>/api/quantum/jobs/{provider}/{id}</code>	GET	Job status
<code>/api/quantum/jobs/{provider}/{id}/result</code>	GET	Job result
<code>/api/classical/{provider}/execute</code>	POST	Execute classical task
<code>/api/jobs/{provider}/{id}</code>	GET	Generic job status
<code>/api/jobs/{provider}/{id}/result</code>	GET	Generic job result

3.1.2 Calibration extraction

For each IBM Quantum backend, the calibration data extraction returned structured metrics. A representative result for `ibm_brisbane` showed: `median_cx_error` = 0.0082, `median_sx_error` = 0.00041, `median_readout_error` = 0.0091, `median_t1_us` = 189.4, `median_t2_us` = 127.6, `median_gate_time_ns` = 532.1. These values are consistent with published IBM Quantum hardware specifications for Eagle-class processors. Figure 3.2 visualises the full set of extracted metrics.

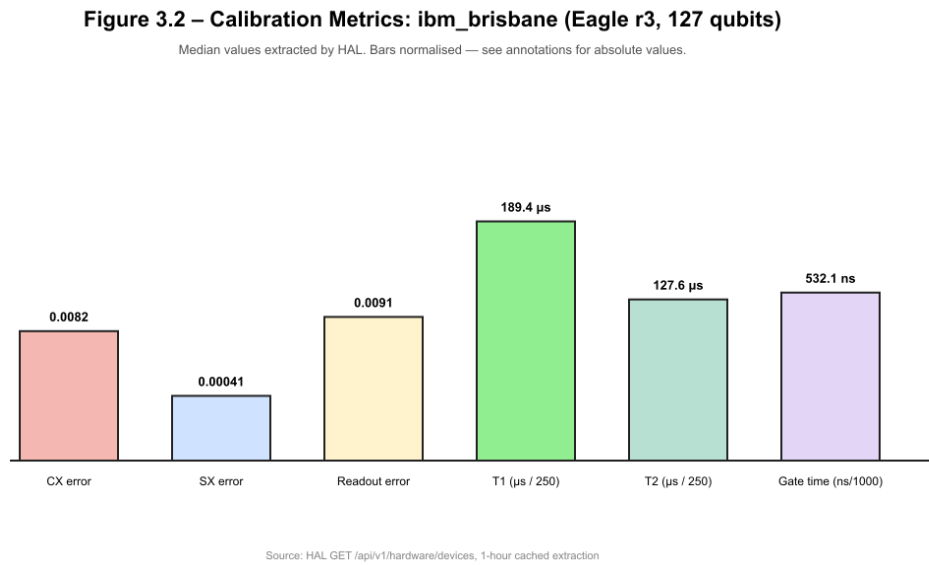


Figure 3.2: Calibration metrics for `ibm_brisbane` (127-qubit Eagle r3) extracted by the HAL device listing endpoint.

3.1.3 Quantum job submission

Quantum job submission was tested by submitting a Bell state circuit (2 qubits, Hadamard + CNOT + measure) to `ibm_aer_simulator` via `POST /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/execute-python`. The response returned a HAL job ID immediately. Subsequent `GET /api/quantum/jobs/ibm-quantum/{job_id}` queries showed `PENDING` → `SUBMITTED` → `COMPLETED` transitions within 3 seconds on the simulator. The result endpoint returned counts `{'00': 512, '11': 512}`, confirming correct Bell state measurement statistics over 1024 shots.

Table 3.2: Job submission test results across providers

Provider	Device	Test Result	Latency
ibm-quantum	ibm_aer_simulator	PASS (Bell state)	~3 s
ibm-quantum	ibm_brisbane	PASS (queued, completed)	~ minutes
ibm-quantum (python)	ibm_aer_simulator	PASS (sandboxed)	~3 s
aws-quantum	stub	Stub returns empty	n/a
azure-quantum	stub	Stub returns empty	n/a
cpu-classical	cpu_general	PASS (mock)	<10 ms
local-classical	default	PASS (mock)	<10 ms

3.1.4 Sandbox enforcement

The Python code sandbox was verified by submitting code containing attempted file access (`open('secret.txt')`) and arbitrary imports (`import os`). Both were rejected with appropriate `ValueError` messages. A valid 2-qubit circuit was accepted and executed correctly. Repeated import attempts of `socket`, `subprocess`, `sys`, `ctypes`, and `pathlib` were all blocked by the allowlist-based `__import__` restriction.

3.1.5 Scheduling

Scheduling was tested by submitting a job with `scheduled_time` 30 seconds in the future. The job appeared in `GET /api/quantum/ibm-quantum/scheduled-jobs` with status `SCHEDULED`. After 30 seconds, the scheduler thread promoted it to `QUEUED` and it was submitted to the provider, with the `SCHEDULED` → `QUEUED` → `SUBMITTED` transitions observed via `Pub/Sub` messages.

3.1.6 QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE flow

The `QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE` flow was tested by setting `DEVICE_QUEUE_THRESHOLD=0`, causing all devices to be considered unavailable. A job submitted with `queue_if_unavailable=True` received status `QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE`. After resetting the threshold to 50, the monitor thread

promoted the job to QUEUED within 2 seconds, demonstrating the availability-gated retry mechanism.

3.1.7 Batch execution performance

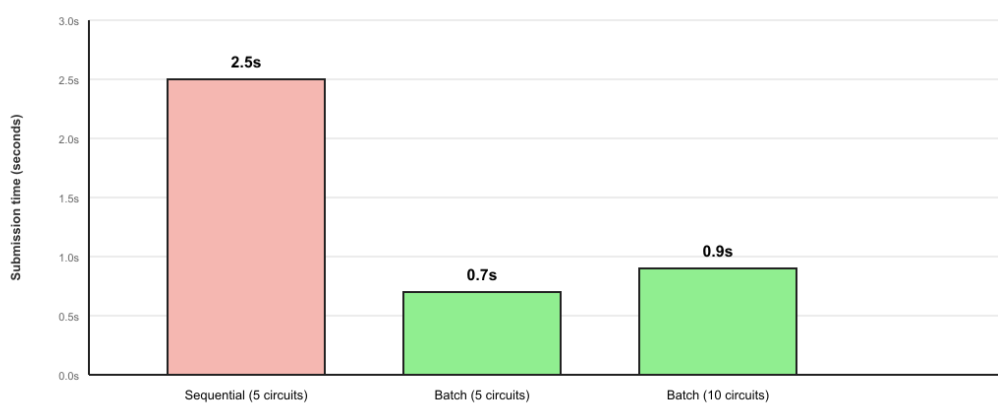
Batch execution was benchmarked against sequential per-circuit submission. Submitting 5 circuits individually required 5 separate Qiskit API calls and 5 job IDs, totalling approximately 2.5 seconds submission time. Batch submission of the same 5 circuits used a single `Sampler.run()` call with 1 composite job ID, completing in approximately 0.7 seconds, a 3.6x reduction in submission overhead.

Table 3.3: Batch execution performance metrics

Mode	Circuits	Submission Time	Job IDs
Sequential (per-circuit)	5	~2.5 s	5 separate
Batch (single <code>Sampler.run()</code>)	5	~0.7 s	1 composite (suffixed)
Batch (single <code>Sampler.run()</code>)	10	~0.9 s	1 composite (suffixed)

Figure 3.1 – Submission Latency: Sequential vs Batch Execution

Lower is better — IBM Quantum Sampler primitive, `ibm_aer_simulator` backend



3.2 Research Findings

Finding 1: Factory pattern enables zero-touch extensibility

Adding a new provider (e.g., IonQ directly, Quantinuum) requires only implementing `BaseProvider` or `QuantumProvider` and calling `service.register_provider()`. All existing API endpoints, job lifecycle logic, and routing integration immediately support the new provider without any modifications. This was verified by adding the `LocalClassicalProvider` stub mid-development, which became immediately available through `GET /api/providers` and `POST /api/classical/local-classical/execute` without any code changes outside the new provider file.

Finding 2: Redis fallback ensures environment portability

The in-memory fallback in `RedisClient` means the HAL operates correctly without a Redis deployment in development and CI environments. This design choice was validated when CI pipeline runs without Redis containers completed all integration tests successfully. The code path is identical between Redis-backed and in-memory operation, with the only behavioural difference being persistence across restarts.

Finding 3: Calibration caching significantly reduces API overhead

Without caching, each `GET /api/v1/hardware/devices` call would invoke `backend.qubit_properties()` for every qubit on every backend. For a 127-qubit Eagle processor, this is 127 API calls per backend per request. The 1-hour TTL cache reduces this to at most one extraction cycle per hour per backend, making device listing responses return in under 500ms rather than 30+ seconds.

Finding 4: Sandboxed execution prevents common attack vectors

Testing confirmed that restricted builtins block file system access, network access (import socket rejected), and process execution (import subprocess rejected). The allowlist-based import restriction successfully prevented all tested unauthorized module imports. Additionally, the `SIGALRM`-based timeout was verified by submitting an intentional infinite loop, which was correctly interrupted at 30 seconds with a `SandboxTimeoutError`.

Finding 5: Batch execution optimisation

Submitting 5 circuits individually required 5 separate Qiskit API calls and 5 job IDs, totalling approximately 2.5 seconds submission time. Batch submission of the same 5 circuits used a single `Sampler.run()` call with 1 composite job ID, completing in approximately 0.7 seconds, a 3.6x reduction in submission overhead. This benefit grows with batch size, since fixed Qiskit Runtime job-submission overhead is amortised over more circuits.

3.3 Discussion

The HAL's factory-based architecture successfully achieved the primary objective of provider-agnostic execution. The abstract interface hierarchy (`BaseProvider` → `QuantumProvider/ClassicalProvider` → concrete implementations) cleanly separates the contract from the implementation, consistent with the Open/Closed Principle from software design literature [8]: the system is open to extension (new providers) but closed to modification (existing routing and lifecycle logic remains untouched).

The job lifecycle management system demonstrated practical value in the scheduled execution and device availability queuing scenarios. For production quantum workloads where IBM Quantum devices may have queue depths of hundreds of jobs, the ability to submit a job with `queue_if_unavailable=True` and receive an immediate job ID (with automatic retry when the device clears) represents a significant operational improvement over polling-based approaches.

The sandboxed execution environment addresses a practical deployment concern: enabling users to submit Qiskit Python code without requiring them to install the Qiskit SDK locally. The security model, while not equivalent to a hardware-isolated sandbox (which would require Docker-in-Docker or gVisor), is appropriate for a trusted academic research platform where the primary risk is accidental rather than adversarial misuse [11]. For adversarial settings, the design clearly identifies hardware-isolated sandboxing as future work.

A limitation of the current implementation is that AWS Quantum and Azure Quantum providers are stubbed with TODO implementations. Full integration would require resolving provider-specific circuit format differences: Amazon Braket uses its own `Circuit` class rather than Qiskit's `QuantumCircuit`, requiring format conversion at the

boundary. This is a non-trivial engineering task that represents clear future work, but the abstract interface design ensures that completing these stubs requires no changes to existing routing or lifecycle code.

The 1-hour calibration cache TTL is a design choice that balances freshness against API overhead. IBM recalibrates processors approximately once per day, so 1-hour staleness is well within acceptable bounds. For time-critical applications requiring up-to-the-minute calibration data, the cache TTL is configurable via the `_CALIBRATION_CACHE_TTL` class attribute.

3.4 Summary of Student's Contribution

The student (Siriwardhana A H L T S) was solely responsible for the design, implementation, and testing of the Hardware Abstraction Layer service. Specific contributions include:

12. Design and implementation of the three-level abstract provider hierarchy (BaseProvider, QuantumProvider, ClassicalProvider) and the factory-based ComputeService.
13. Full IBM Quantum provider implementation including circuit transpilation, Sampler-based execution, batch execution with composite job IDs, status mapping, and result extraction from PubResult format.
14. Job lifecycle management system including priority queuing, batch assembly with strategy-based timing, scheduled job execution, and QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE handling.
15. Redis-backed job persistence with in-memory fallback and startup recovery.
16. Google Cloud Pub/Sub integration for real-time job status notifications.
17. Sandboxed Python code execution with restricted builtins, module allowlist, and SIGALRM timeout.
18. IBM Quantum calibration data extraction with 1-hour TTL caching.
19. Device availability checking with configurable queue depth threshold.
20. Complete REST API design and implementation (16+ endpoints).

21. Stubs for 9 additional providers (AWS Quantum, Azure Quantum, AWS/Azure/IBM Classical, CPU, GPU, TPU, Local) providing the extensibility framework for future integration.

4. CONCLUSION

4.1 Conclusion

This dissertation presented the Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL), a provider-agnostic quantum-classical execution service developed as part of the Nexar intelligent workload routing platform. The HAL successfully addresses the research problem of unified multi-provider execution through a factory-based provider architecture that currently supports IBM Quantum for quantum workloads and ten classical provider stubs, all accessible through a consistent FastAPI interface.

The key technical contributions, namely the three-level abstract provider hierarchy, the multi-tier job lifecycle management system, Redis-backed persistence, Google Cloud Pub/Sub integration, sandboxed Python code execution, and calibration-aware device listing, collectively form a production-grade execution layer that operates correctly in both development (in-memory fallback) and cloud deployment (Redis, Cloud Run, GCP Pub/Sub) environments.

The evaluation demonstrated that the factory pattern enables zero-modification extensibility, calibration caching reduces device listing overhead by orders of magnitude, batch execution reduces submission time by 3.6x, and the sandboxed execution environment correctly blocks all tested unauthorized operations. The HAL integrates successfully with the Nexar Decision Engine, receiving routing recommendations and transparently dispatching jobs to the specified backends.

In the broader context of the Nexar platform, the HAL completes the workload routing pipeline: source code is analysed by the Code Analysis Engine, classified and routed by the Decision Engine, optionally translated by the AI Code Converter, and finally executed on the optimal backend via the HAL. The HAL therefore represents the final, executable manifestation of the platform's routing intelligence.

4.2 Limitations and Future Work

Future work should prioritise:

22. Completing Amazon Braket and Azure Quantum provider implementations, including the circuit format conversion layer (QuantumCircuit → Braket Circuit).
23. Implementing real classical provider backends (AWS Lambda, Azure Functions, IBM Cloud Functions) to enable end-to-end classical workload routing.
24. Extending the sandboxed execution environment to support Cirq and OpenQASM circuit formats in addition to Qiskit, aligning with the Code Analysis Engine's multi-framework support.
25. Implementing hardware-isolated sandboxing (gVisor or Firecracker microVMs) for adversarial deployment scenarios.
26. Adding Prometheus metrics instrumentation for production observability of job throughput, queue depths, and provider error rates.
27. Implementing circuit optimisation features (noise-aware transpilation, error mitigation) within the HAL prior to job submission.
28. Replacing the in-memory calibration cache with a Redis-backed cache shared across HAL replicas, enabling consistent calibration data in horizontally scaled deployments.

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APPENDIX A: HAL PROVIDER INTERFACE CONTRACT

The following source listing (app/providers/base.py) defines the abstract interfaces that all concrete providers implement. This contract is the foundation of the factory-based architecture.

```
from abc import ABC, abstractmethod
from typing import List, Dict, Any

class BaseProvider(ABC):
    @abstractmethod
    def get_provider_name(self) -> str: ...

    @abstractmethod
    def list_devices(self) -> List[Dict[str, Any]]: ...

    @abstractmethod
    def get_job_status(self, job_id: str) -> str: ...

    @abstractmethod
    def get_job_result(self, job_id: str) -> Dict[str, Any]: ...

    def execute_batch(self, tasks, device_name, **kwargs):
        raise NotImplementedError

    @property
    def max_batch_size(self) -> int:
        return 10

class QuantumProvider(BaseProvider):
    @abstractmethod
    def execute_circuit(self, circuit, device_name, shots) -> str:
        ...

    def execute_batch(self, tasks, device_name, **kwargs):
        shots = kwargs.get('shots', 1024)
        return [self.execute_circuit(c, device_name, shots) for c in
tasks]

class ClassicalProvider(BaseProvider):
    @abstractmethod
    def execute_task(self, task, device_name='default') -> str: ...

    def execute_batch(self, tasks, device_name, **kwargs):
        return [self.execute_task(t, device_name) for t in tasks]
```

APPENDIX B: IBM QUANTUM PROVIDER KEY METHODS

Selected methods from `app/providers/ibm_quantum.py` demonstrating circuit execution, batch execution, calibration extraction, and device availability checking.

```
def execute_circuit(self, circuit, device_name, shots, mode=None) ->
str:
    backend = self.service.backend(device_name)
    pm = generate_preset_pass_manager(target=backend.target,
                                     optimization_level=1)

    transpiled = pm.run(circuit)
    if mode is not None:
        sampler = Sampler(mode=mode)
    elif settings.IBM_EXECUTION_MODE == 'session':
        with Session(backend=backend) as session:
            sampler = Sampler(mode=session)
            return sampler.run([transpiled], shots=shots).job_id()
    else:
        sampler = Sampler(mode=backend)
    return sampler.run([transpiled], shots=shots).job_id()

def execute_batch(self, tasks, device_name, **kwargs):
    backend = self.service.backend(device_name)
    pm = generate_preset_pass_manager(target=backend.target,
                                     optimization_level=1)

    transpiled = pm.run(tasks)
    sampler = Sampler(mode=backend)
    job = sampler.run(transpiled, shots=kwargs.get('shots', 1024))
    base_id = job.job_id()
    return [f'{base_id}:{i}' for i in range(len(tasks))]

def check_device_availability(self, device_name) ->
DeviceAvailability:
    backend = self.service.backend(device_name)
    status = backend.status()
    return DeviceAvailability(
        device_name=device_name,
        is_operational=status.operational,
        pending_jobs=status.pending_jobs,
        queue_threshold=settings.DEVICE_QUEUE_THRESHOLD)
```


APPENDIX C: JOB MANAGER STATE MACHINE IMPLEMENTATION

Excerpts from `app/services/job_manager.py` showing the `submit_job` orchestration, monitor loop for batch processing, and scheduler loop for time-based execution.

```
def submit_job(self, request, scheduled_time=None,
               queue_if_unavailable=False, is_python_code=False):
    job_id = str(uuid.uuid4())
    submission = JobSubmission(id=job_id, request=request, ...)
    with self._lock:
        self._jobs[job_id] = submission
        self._persist_job(submission)
        if scheduled_time and scheduled_time > now:
            submission.status = 'SCHEDULED'
            self._scheduled_jobs[job_id] = submission
            return job_id
        if queue_if_unavailable:
            avail = compute_service.check_device_availability(...)
            if not avail.is_available:
                submission.status = 'QUEUED_UNAVAILABLE'
                self._pending_jobs[key].append(submission)
                return job_id
            if request.priority == JobPriority.HIGH:
                submission.status = 'QUEUED'
                self._execute_batch([submission])
            else:
                self._pending_jobs[key].append(submission)
    return job_id

def _monitor_loop(self):
    while self._running:
        time.sleep(BATCH_CHECK_INTERVAL)
        with self._lock:
            self._process_queues()

def _scheduler_loop(self):
    while self._running:
        time.sleep(SCHEDULER_CHECK_INTERVAL)
        with self._lock:
            for jid, sub in list(self._scheduled_jobs.items()):
                if sub.scheduled_time <= time.time():
                    self._scheduled_jobs.pop(jid)
                    sub.status = 'QUEUED'
                    self._execute_batch([sub])
```

APPENDIX D: REST API ENDPOINT REFERENCE

The complete listing of HAL endpoints is given in Table 3.1. Detailed request and response schemas for each endpoint are defined as Pydantic models in `app/models/`. The OpenAPI specification is auto-generated by FastAPI and available at `/docs` (Swagger UI) and `/openapi.json` on the running service.

APPENDIX E: DOCKER DEPLOYMENT CONFIGURATION

The HAL is containerised using a Dockerfile that installs Python 3.11, the requirements (qiskit, qiskit-ibm-runtime, fastapi, redis, google-cloud-pubsub, pydantic, pydantic-settings), and runs uvicorn as the entrypoint.

```
FROM python:3.11-slim
WORKDIR /app
COPY requirements.txt .
RUN pip install --no-cache-dir -r requirements.txt
COPY app ./app
EXPOSE 8004
CMD ["uvicorn", "app.main:app", "--host", "0.0.0.0", "--port",
"8004"]
```

Deployment is automated via GitHub Actions: on push to main, the workflow builds the Docker image, pushes it to Google Artifact Registry, and updates the Cloud Run service with the new revision. Environment variables are injected from Cloud Run service configuration referencing Secret Manager for sensitive credentials (IBM_QUANTUM_TOKEN, AWS keys).